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Body Recomposition

Lose fat *and* build muscle at the same time — the honest, science-based system (no crash diets, no bulk/cut confusion).

Most advice says you can only do one at a time. That's half the story. Here's what the research actually shows, and the daily system that makes it work — built on one idea: **consistency beats intensity.**

By Youssef Raihane · Motiva Hub · The-Motivahub.com

What recomposition actually is

Body recomposition means changing your **body composition** — losing fat tissue while gaining muscle tissue — instead of just dropping scale weight. On the scale you might barely move, but your waist shrinks and your lifts go up. That's the win.

Cut vs Bulk vs Recomposition

Approach	Goal	Best for
Cut (deficit)	Lose fat, keep muscle	Already muscular, wants definition
Bulk (surplus)	Gain muscle (some fat)	Very lean / underweight, advanced
Recomp	Lose fat + gain muscle	Beginners, higher body fat, returning lifters

Who it works best for

- **1 New to lifting (or returning).** "Newbie gains" are real — untrained muscles respond to almost any stimulus, so you can add muscle even in a slight deficit.
- **2 Higher body fat.** You have ample energy stored in fat to "power" muscle growth.
- **3 Detrained.** Coming back after a break, muscle memory accelerates regrowth.

Be honest about the timeline

Recomp is **slower** than a dedicated cut or bulk — especially if you're already trained and lean. Expect subtle change over **8–16 weeks**, not 2. If you're advanced and already lean, a traditional cut→bulk phase may serve you better. This guide is for the majority who aren't.

Three levers (and one silent one)

Fat loss and muscle gain pull in opposite energy directions, so people assume they can't happen together. They can — if you set the right hormonal and mechanical signals. The science reduces to three levers you control, plus recovery in the background.

Lever 1 • Training

Resistance training is the **signal** that tells your body to keep/build muscle while you lose fat. No lifting → most of the weight you drop is muscle.

Lever 2 • Protein

High protein feeds muscle repair *and* keeps you full. It's the single most important diet variable for recomp.

Lever 3 • Energy

Eat **around maintenance** or a small deficit. You don't need to starve — fat loss comes mostly from the training + protein combo.

Silent lever • Sleep

Under-sleeping shifts your body to lose **more muscle and less fat** for the same deficit. It's not optional.

The discipline angle (why this fits a habit system): none of these levers is hard — they're just *repeatable*. Recomposition isn't a project you feel motivated about; it's a set of daily defaults you run on autopilot. Motivation starts it, the system finishes it.

Train with progressive overload

One rule matters most: **over time, do more** — more weight, more reps, or better technique on the same lifts. This is *progressive overload*, and it's what forces muscle growth regardless of your calories.

The non-negotiables

- **Frequency:** hit each muscle **2x/week**. Aim for 3–4 sessions total. Full-body or upper/lower beats a "bro split" for recomp.
- **Compound-first:** squat, hinge/deadlift, push (bench/push-up/press), pull (row/pull-up), carry. These give the most signal per minute.
- **Intensity:** take most sets close to failure — stop with ~1–3 reps left in the tank.
- **Volume:** start low, ~**10–20 hard sets** per muscle per week. Add slowly.
- **Progress:** log every session. A number going up over weeks = you're building muscle.

Sample 4-week template (3x/week full body)

Day	Main work	Sets × Reps
A	Goblet/Back Squat · Push-up/Bench · Row	3–4 × 6–12
B	Deadlift/Hinge · Overhead Press · Pull-up/Lat pulldown	3–4 × 6–12
C	Lunge/Split squat · Incline press · Face pull + Carry	2–3 × 8–15

Each week, add a small rep or weight to at least one lift. That's the whole game.

Protein is the anchor

When you eat less energy than you burn, protein is what protects (and builds) muscle. It's also the most filling macronutrient — it does your discipline work for you by killing cravings.

Target: 1.6–2.2 g of protein per kg of bodyweight per day ($\approx$ 0.7–1.0 g per lb). The upper end helps most when you're in a bigger deficit or training hard.

Make it practical

- **Spread it:** 3–4 meals with **$\sim$ 0.4 g/kg each** beats one giant serving. You need a repeatable rhythm, not perfection.
- **Front-load it:** a high-protein breakfast stabilises appetite for the whole day.
- **Protein first at every meal** — build the plate around it, then add vegetables and carbs.

Best sources (pick what you actually eat)

Animal eggs · chicken · turkey · lean beef · fish · Greek yogurt · cottage cheese · whey

Plant tofu · tempeh · seitan · lentils · beans · edamame · soy/pea protein · high-protein grains

Example: 75 kg person $\rightarrow$ $\sim$ 120–165 g/day $\rightarrow$ four meals of $\sim$ 30–40 g. That's a palm of protein per meal, three to four times a day.

Eat near maintenance. Sleep like it's part of the workout.

Unlike a hard cut, recomp works best when you **don't starve yourself**. A big deficit costs you muscle and willpower. You want just enough of a nudge to lose fat while training + protein drive muscle gain.

Simple starting rules

- Find your **maintenance** roughly: eat normally for 1–2 weeks, track intake — the calories where weight stays flat.
- If carrying extra fat: eat a **small deficit (~10–20%)** below that. If skinny-lean: eat **at maintenance** or a tiny surplus.
- Keep protein at target (Lever 2). Let carbs/fats flex around it — carbs around training help performance.

Sleep & stress — the silent multiplier

Research on energy restriction shows that cutting sleep from ~9h to ~5h shifts weight loss toward **more muscle lost and less fat lost**, plus more hunger. Sleep and stress management aren't "wellness fluff" — they change *what kind* of tissue you lose.

- **7–9 hours**, consistent times.
- Steps / daily movement (8–10k) — cheap fat-loss that doesn't tax recovery.
- One rest day a week. Recovery is when muscle is actually built.

The weekly default (run it on autopilot)

Stop deciding every day. Lock these as **defaults** — that's the whole discipline trick. You don't rise to your goals, you fall to your systems.

Pillar	The default
Training	3–4 sessions, log every set, add a little weekly
Protein	~0.4 g/kg at 3–4 meals · protein first
Energy	Near maintenance / small deficit — no crash
Movement	8–10k steps daily
Sleep	7–9h, fixed wake time
Track	Weekly average weight + photos + one lift number

Habit-stacking for consistency

Tie the new defaults to things you already do, so they don't rely on motivation:

- "After I pour my morning coffee, I eat my high-protein breakfast."
- "After I close my laptop, my gym bag is already by the door."
- "Every Sunday I plan the week's 3 workouts and set my protein target."

The rule that saves you: never miss twice. You'll skip a workout or overeat. That's data, not failure. Get back on the very next opportunity. One miss is noise; a second is the start of a new habit. The person who finishes is the person who restarts fastest.

Track what actually changes

Recomp often hides on the scale — you gain muscle while losing fat, so weight stays flat while your body changes. If you only watch the scale, you'll quit right before it's working. Use better signals:

- **Weekly average weight** (daily noise is meaningless; the trend matters).
- **Progress photos** every 2–4 weeks, same light/angle.
- **Waist measurement** — often drops before weight does.
- **Strength numbers** going up = muscle is being kept or built.

Green flag weight flat/down slowly + lifts up + waist shrinking = **recomposition is happening**. This is the goal, even if the scale "isn't moving."

What to eat — build the plate

No forbidden foods, just a repeatable structure. Every main meal:

- **½ plate vegetables** (volume, fibre, fullness for few calories).
- **A palm-to-two of protein** (your per-meal target).
- **Carbs around training** (rice, potato, oats, fruit, bread) — fuel for the lever that matters.
- **Healthy fats** in moderation (olive oil, nuts, avocado) — for hormones & satiety.

Minimise the real levers of failure: liquid calories, mindless evening snacking, and "I'll be good tomorrow" weekend binges that erase a week's deficit.

The 30-day recomposition starter

Four weeks to install the system. Don't chase perfection — chase **the repeat**.

Week 1 — Baseline. Train 3× (learn the lifts, log them). Set a protein target and hit it most days. Take "before" photos + waist + weight. Sleep 7h+. *Goal: measure, don't optimise yet.*

Week 2 — Protein & steps. Add protein at every meal. Hit 8–10k steps daily. Add a small rep/weight to one lift per session. *Goal: make protein automatic.*

Week 3 — Progress overload. Push training a notch (extra set or weight). Fix meal timing around workouts. Compare week-3 photos to week-1. *Goal: numbers trending up.*

Week 4 — Review & adjust. If weight is flat and lifts up → you're recomping, stay the course. If losing too fast and stalled lifts → add a little food. If nothing moving after 4 weeks → check protein + steps + tracking honesty. *Goal: turn 30 days into "just how I eat and train."*

The identity shift: by day 30 you're not "someone trying to get in shape." You're someone who trains, eats protein, and shows up — even on bad days. That identity is the result. The body follows it.

Quick answers

Do I need to count calories? Not forever. Estimate maintenance once, keep protein fixed, use steps + how clothes fit. Scale-based tracking is optional.

Can advanced/lean people recomp? Yes, but slowly. If you're already muscular and lean, a traditional cut or bulk is usually more efficient.

Cardio? Keep it simple — daily steps first. Optional 1–2 easy sessions for health. Don't let cardio cannibalise recovery from lifting.

Supplements? None required. Creatine monohydrate (3–5 g/day) and vitamin D (if deficient) are the only well-supported basics.

The evidence

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Disclaimer: This guide is general educational information, not medical advice. Consult a qualified professional before starting any diet or exercise program, especially with existing health conditions. Individual results vary.